

NAVAL GUNS AND KIT

Naval cannon first appeared in the mid-14th century in the form of wrought-iron breech-loaders. Cast-bronze muzzle-loaders were developed in the 16th century, and by the 18th century all European navies were widely using cast-iron muzzle-loaders, such as the British versions shown here. To charge muzzle-loaders of this type, a fabric powder cartridge was loaded down the muzzle and into the chamber, followed by a rope wad to hold it in place, the shot, and a second rope wad. The charge was pricked by inserting a wire pricker into the vent, then the gunpowder was poured in. Either a gunlock or a slow match held at the vent hole was used to fire the gun.



Slow match burned at a rate of 30cm (12in) every three hours

◀ MATCH TUB AND SLOW MATCHES

Date c.1800

Origin UK

Material Wood, hemp

A slow match was lit at the start of the battle and placed in the match tub. It kept burning and was used to ignite the charge if the gunlock failed. Made from hemp, the slow match was boiled in a solution of spirits of wine and saltpetre.

Wooden keg

▶ CAST-IRON 24-POUNDER

Date 1785–1822

Origin UK

Weight 2.9 tonnes (3.2 tons)

Length 2.9m (9½ft)

Calibre 5.8in

Shot 11kg (24lb)

Naval guns were mounted on wheeled wooden carriages, allowing them to run backwards under recoil. This motion was controlled by restraining ropes around the breech or carriage.



Canvas sheet

▲ CARTRIDGE

Date c.1800

Origin UK

Material Canvas

Paper, canvas, or parchment were sewn into different size cylinders as gunpowder containers. A precise amount of gunpowder was used depending on the gun and the type of charge.



Vent for igniting powder charge

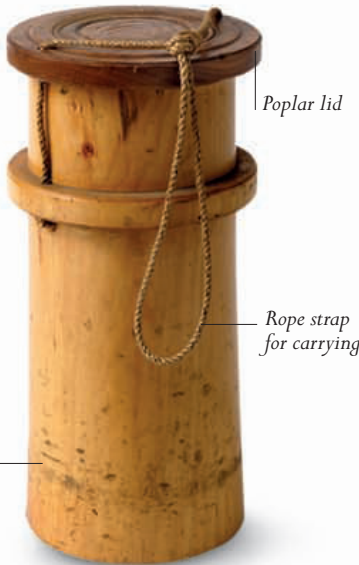
◀ ROPE WAD

Date c.1800

Origin UK

Material Rope

Oddments of rope and rope fibre (oakum, or “junk”) were used to make wads, which were rammed down the barrel of the gun to hold the charge and shot in place.



Elm cylinder

Poplar lid

Rope strap for carrying

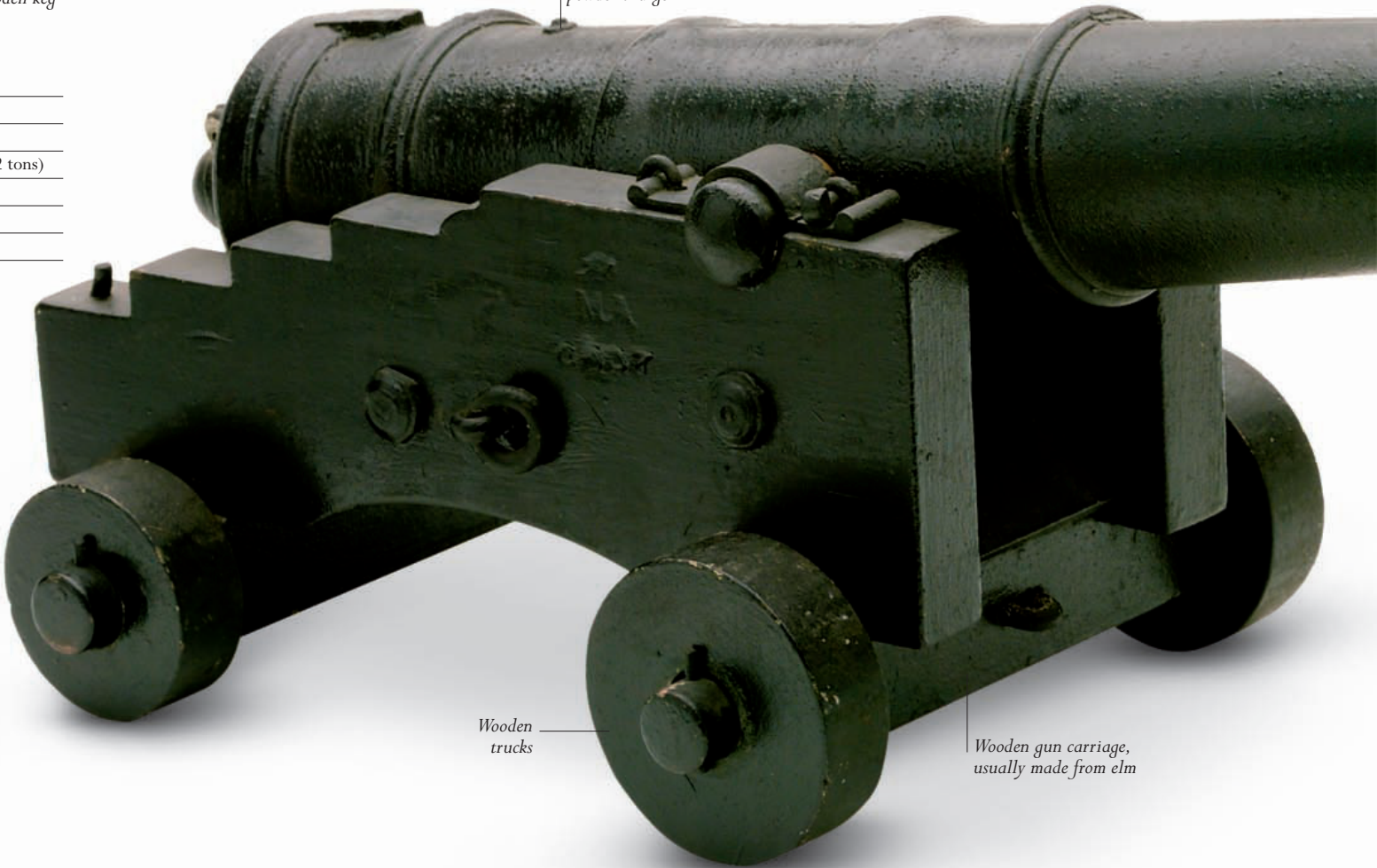
▲ CARTRIDGE CASE

Date c.1800

Origin UK

Material Wood

To prevent accidental explosions, cartridges had to be carried with great care from the magazines to the guns. A lightweight wooden cylinder was used to protect and carry each cartridge.



Wooden trucks

Wooden gun carriage, usually made from elm